La Odisea del .ia · ECI(2026)000012

Chapter 1: The Island That Rented Out the Future

Why the most powerful technology of our time wears the label of a Caribbean tax haven, and how the idea of creating the .ia Designation of Origin was born

The first time I asked myself the question, I thought the answer would be obvious.

Every single day we open dozens of websites, medical apps, financial assistants, educational tools, or news services ending in the same two letters: .ai. We take for granted that this suffix stands for Artificial Intelligence. Almost without thinking, we assume that behind those two letters stands some international technological registry—an institution verifying that what we are using is genuine artificial intelligence and that it abides by basic safety rules.

There is nothing of the sort.

Back in 1995, when Internet country codes were handed out, every territory on Earth was assigned two letters: .es for Spain, .fr for France, .de for Germany. Anguilla, a tiny British Overseas Territory in the Caribbean spanning barely ninety square kilometers with fifteen thousand inhabitants, was randomly assigned .ai.

For nearly thirty years, hardly anyone outside that island—famous for its coral beaches and zero-tax regime—cared about that domain. Until the artificial intelligence gold rush erupted. Overnight, thousands of companies, labs, and speculators across the globe began paying tens of millions of dollars to rent web addresses ending in .ai simply because, in English, those letters happened to match the acronym of the century.

Today, a massive share of the new digital economy operates under the flag of a Caribbean island that collects a multi-million-dollar toll for every registration while demanding not a single guarantee from the buyer. It makes no difference whether behind a .ai website stands a legitimate scientific team, an opaque system secretly trading your children's medical records, or an automated scam accountable to no European court. As long as you pay the annual fee, you wear the exact same badge on the door.

What We Learned Centuries Ago Around the Dinner Table

When I discovered how that market actually worked, I thought of something much closer to everyday life.

In Europe, we have spent generations protecting what comes into our homes. When you buy a bottle of olive oil, wine, or cheese bearing a Protected Designation of Origin, you do not need to be an agricultural engineer or test the product in a laboratory before serving it to your family. That seal on the label tells you three things immediately:

1. It possesses proven intrinsic quality, the result of clear production standards.
2. There is full traceability, from its origin to your hands.
3. Someone is legally accountable, subject to real inspections and European law, who loses the seal the moment they deceive the public.

Imagine a supermarket where any manufacturer in the world could stamp "Designation of Origin" on a bottle simply by wiring fifty dollars to a Caribbean office, without passing a single health inspection. We would find it outrageous.

Yet that is precisely what we are allowing with the technology that already drafts contracts, filters job applications, diagnoses illnesses, tutors our teenagers, and shapes public opinion. We have flooded the Internet with unlabeled bottles and let them disguise themselves under the name of a tropical island.

Two Letters That Belong to Us: .ia

That was when I noticed a second anomaly, even more striking than the first.

Over six hundred million people worldwide—and hundreds of millions of citizens across the European Union—speak languages in which this technology is not even abbreviated AI. In Spanish, French, Italian, Portuguese, and Romanian, it is called Inteligencia Artificial / Intelligence Artificielle / Intelligenza Artificiale (IA).

I looked up the .ia domain on the official map of the Internet. It belonged to no country. It was not leased to any tax haven. It sat empty in a technical limbo, waiting for someone to define why it should exist.

And that was the spark that kept me awake at night:

What if, instead of using .ia to auction off web addresses to the highest bidder, the

European Union claimed and established the .ia domain as the world's first digital Designation of Origin?

A space on the Internet where carrying the .ia extension would not be a matter of checkbooks, but a seal of intrinsic quality: an immediate guarantee to every citizen that the service meets genuine transparency standards, respects human privacy, honestly discloses when you are interacting with a machine, and is legally accountable on European soil.

From a Sketch on Paper to the Doors of Strasbourg

I could have simply written an op-ed about this, posted it on social media, received a few polite pats on the back, and watched the idea fade away within forty-eight hours.

Instead, tucked inside the treaties of the European Union lies an instrument very few people know about—and even fewer dare to use: the European Citizens' Initiative (ECI). It is not a symbolic petition on a private website. It is an official legislative mechanism: if a committee of citizens from at least seven EU Member States persuades the European Commission to register their proposal and gathers one million verified signatures, the executive branch of Europe is legally bound to respond and open the legislative pathway.

People told me it was virtually impossible for the European Commission to register such a proposal coming from ordinary citizens—without a political party, without a Brussels lobbying firm, and without tech giants behind us.

They were wrong.

On October 6, 2026, meeting in Strasbourg, the College of Commissioners of the European Union formally adopted Decision C(2026) 7098 final, registering our initiative under the official code ECI(2026)000012 and provisioning the official electronic ballot box where citizens will decide whether the .ia domain becomes European law.

This chronicle, which I will publish chapter by chapter at odisea.deft.work, is the true story of how we got here, how a .ia Designation of Origin can transform our daily lives, and how we are going to gather those one million signatures together.

In the next chapter, I will tell you why this entire journey began by looking back at

a shipwreck sunk two thousand years ago in the Aegean Sea—and how seven strangers across seven countries joined forces to turn the first key in Brussels.